

Source (1/3): <https://wellcome.org/what-we-do/mental-health/mental-health-data-prize>

Wellcome Mental Health Data Prizes

We support teams to use existing data to uncover new insights and create digital tools for research into anxiety and depression in young people.

What are data prizes?

Data prizes are an open competition or challenge where participants use data to solve a societal problem.

They are increasingly used to find solutions to complex issues and can be especially powerful for areas blocked by siloed research fields, where funding is limited, or when there is a lack of motivation because progress has slowed.

Wellcome Mental Health Data Prize: Africa, 2024

Our newest data prize will fund teams across the African continent to analyse data and build digital tools to answer the question: “What can help us tackle anxiety, depression and psychosis in Africa?”

We are working with [The African Population and Health Research Center \(APHRC\)](#) to run this prize. They will deliver training, facilitate access to data sources from across the continent and support teams through the prize.

At present, the APHRC is helping to build capacity for the prize across the continent. So far, over 2430 data scientists and researchers from 31 African member states have registered for tailored support and training on topics ranging from basic data and mental health research to advanced statistical analysis and machine learning.

Additionally, matchmaking events have brought together over 380 potential applicants, encouraging people with diverse knowledge, skillsets and backgrounds to collaborate and develop proposals together.

Applications for the Africa prize are open the submission deadline is 30 July.

Wellcome Mental Health Data Prize: UK and South Africa, 2022-2023

The first Wellcome Data Prize was delivered in partnership with [Social Finance](#) and was open to teams in the UK and South Africa, £1.4 million was awarded across three phases, with the top prize of £500,000 shared between the three winning teams. The prize ended in June 2024.

We designed the prize to prioritise inclusivity, creativity and multidisciplinary working. Lived experience was embedded throughout – from design to delivery – and tools were co-created with lived experience experts to ensure they have a lasting impact.

[Find out about the eligibility, evaluation criteria and design of the prize. We are using what we learned to inform the structure of the new Data Prize in Africa.](#)

"I have been a member of many funding panels and the Wellcome Mental Health Data Prize stood out in terms of the diversity of applicants. The prize really reached beyond the usual suspects with applicants from various geographies, career stages and institutions from both inside and outside the academic landscape, which will bring new perspectives to the research area."

Ann John, Chair of the Mental Health Data Prize Selection Panel

Source (2/3):

<https://wellcome.org/grant-funding/schemes/wellcome-mental-health-data-prize>

Wellcome Mental Health Data Prize

The Wellcome Data Prize in mental health will support collaborative approaches to research into anxiety and depression in young people. Teams in the UK and South Africa will explore existing data to find new insights and build digital tools that enable future research.

This scheme is now closed

Funding amount:

There are three phases to the prize, each six months long and with different levels of funding and support on offer:

- Discovery phase: 10 teams will be selected to receive £40,000 of funding
- Prototyping phase: 5 teams will be selected to receive £100,000 of funding

- Sustainability phase: £500,000 will be allocated across 3 winning teams

Funding duration:

6-18 months

We have partnered with [Social Finance](#) to deliver this prize. To register your interest and get updates please [sign up to the Social Finance mailing list](#).

Coapplicants:

Accepted

Next key date

Calculating next key date...

[View all key dates](#)

About this prize

The Prize aims to generate tangible and scalable outputs that support the mental health research community. The overarching question for the Data Prize is:

What are the 'active ingredients' that make a difference in preventing, treating, and managing anxiety and depression in young people? What works, for whom, in what contexts, and why?

[Read more about our work on active ingredients.](#)

What are 'active ingredients'?

'Active ingredients' are those aspects most likely to make a difference in preventing, treating or managing mental health difficulties. This means they:

- drive clinical effect
- are conceptually well-defined, and
- link to specific, hypothesised mechanisms of action.

Since 2020, Wellcome has been commissioning research teams from across the world to review the evidence for different active ingredients deemed to help prevent, treat, and manage anxiety and/or depression in 14 to 24-year-olds globally.

So far, [over 50 research teams have been commissioned to review 46 active ingredients](#). These active ingredients can be broadly categorised by their focus of change into six groups:

1. behaviours and activities
2. beliefs and knowledge
3. brain/body functions
4. cognitive and attentional skills

5. human connections
6. socioeconomic factors

Reviews into active ingredients have aimed to improve understanding of:

- whether existing evidence shows that their active ingredient is effective among 14 to 24-year-olds
- whether there are subgroups or contexts in which their ingredient is particularly effective or ineffective
- the mechanisms of action underpinning the efficacy of their active ingredient.

It is important to stress that the 46 active ingredients focussed on so far do not represent an exhaustive list. Applicants to the prize are encouraged to propose research that expands the scope of the existing research, for example, by identifying new active ingredients. Additionally, the age range of children and young people of interest to this prize (0-30-year-olds) is wider than in the reviews conducted to-date, providing further opportunities for innovation in research.

Prize structure

There are three phases to the prize, with only a subset of teams from each phase progressing to the next:

1. Discovery Phase (10 teams)

- Participants will be directed to exemplar longitudinal datasets from the UK and South Africa, and can bring their own data where relevant.
- Teams will produce an analysis of existing data to answer a research question.
- Teams will be supported with data acquisition, and refining use cases (further examination of how, why and where the digital tool they develop could be used) as well as lived experience involvement approaches.

2. Prototyping Phase (5 teams)

- Teams will create a prototype of a digital tool, and they will also refine and disseminate their research from the discovery phase.
- Teams will be supported with further developing use cases, lived experience involvement approaches and workshops on agile principles and prototyping.

3. Sustainability Phase (3 teams)

- Support includes data science and product design expertise, support on planning user testing and lived experience involvement approaches and continuous feedback sessions.

Eligibility and suitability

Scope of proposals

Applicants must submit a research question in an area of their interest. Then, the successful awardees will explore existing datasets to help answer that question while developing their analysis tool.

Proposals will be evaluated on impact, innovation and feasibility. Key considerations also include the breadth of skills within teams and how teams plan to involve lived experience of youth anxiety and depression throughout their work.

Analysis does not need to be limited to the [46 active ingredients where we have previously commissioned research](#) and can be on aspects of any intervention most likely to be contributing to making the difference in preventing, treating, or managing ongoing mental health difficulties.

Primary research is out of scope and proposals should not intend to perform primary data collection.

By the end of the award, teams will have produced:

- a digital tool to facilitate data analysis in the mental health research community, and
- the analysis of the datasets they explored.

What do we mean by digital tools?

Tools will build on insights formed in the Discovery phase.

The primary users of these tools will be mental health researchers with the purpose of enabling research into [active ingredients](#), those aspects of an intervention that drive a clinical effect.

Many types of tools could be developed in the prize and we will accept prototypes as an output.

Below are the types of tools that are considered in scope for the Prize.

- Tools helping researchers to **perform** data analysis, for example a tool that can identify clusters of individuals who respond to specific interventions or active ingredients, or a tool that determines which factors can predict relapses.

- Tools used to **replicate** data analysis, by making available the mechanism by which data is translated into research insights, for example, a new application of a machine learning algorithm that can be used on other datasets.
- Tools that **share** the insights from data analysis, in a format accessible and digestible for multiple audiences, for example, a triaging tool for researchers that can highlight the active ingredients that work for different groups of young people.
- Tools that **facilitate** data analysis by addressing barriers to conducting research, for example, tools that support data cleaning and manipulation or automatically extract relevant data from longitudinal datasets.

Please note this list is not exhaustive and serves only as a guideline for what may be developed.

Tools considered out of scope would be:

- Tools based on insights from data but not directly linked to data itself, for example, analysis shows that certain interventions are effective leading to a tool connecting individuals that use that intervention.
- Apps aimed at individuals, for example, condition management, mood tracking, sleep/exercise monitoring apps or a digital tool that supports people directly with navigating existing services for themselves.

Teams do not necessarily need to pursue the same digital tool as proposed in the application, particularly if the need for the tool evolves as a result of the analysis performed. We encourage teams to incorporate their learnings from the discovery phase into the digital tool they ultimately develop.

Intellectual property (IP)

The IP developed with Wellcome's funding should be owned by the organisation with principal responsibility for administering the grant. That notwithstanding, the IP should be made available publicly on an appropriate open-source software licence in line with [Wellcome's open access policy](#).

About you

A key aim of this prize is to build a multidisciplinary mental health data community by bringing together people with mental health research backgrounds and data expertise. By mental health science we mean any discipline that uses evidence in rigorous and transparent ways, whether based on observation or experimentation. This could include:

- psychiatry
- psychology
- neuroscience
- disciplines within the humanities, social sciences and computer sciences, among others.

We also welcome early career researchers.

We understand that groups may want to apply but feel they require additional skillsets, and we will actively support the formation of teams where possible by connecting expertise to those with similar interests and aims across organisations.

For applicants who do not yet have a full multi-disciplinary team, Social Finance will be coordinating opportunities to form connections with other interested organisations. Please sign up to the [mailing list](#) to find out more about these events and join [the Slack channel](#) to meet other people interested in forming a team.

Please see the eligibility criteria below for further information on who can apply.

Eligibility Criteria

Lead applicants:

- must be based in the UK or South Africa.
- may be at any career stage but must have a permanent, open-ended or long-term rolling contract, or the guarantee of one for the full duration of the award.

Lead applicants must be based at an eligible host organisation that can sign up to our [grant conditions](#).

Only the lead applicant from each team needs to be based in the UK or South Africa

Lead applicant organisations should be either:

- a higher education institution
- a research institute
- a non-academic healthcare organisation
- a not-for-profit organisation.

Co-applicants:

- can be at any career stage and based anywhere in the world, apart from mainland China.
- can be self-employed, e.g. a freelance data scientist (as well as employed by the usual range of host organisations below).

Co-applicants must be based at an eligible organisation that can sign up to our [grant conditions](#).

Co-applicants organisations should be either:

- higher education institution
- research institute
- non-academic healthcare organisation
- not-for-profit organisation
- commercial organisation.
- freelancers – such as data scientists

All applicants must agree to our [standard grant conditions](#).

All applicants must make a significant and essential contribution to the work.

Data

Teams can propose their own datasets as research data, with the potential gain of opening them for analysis from a range of expertise after the prize.

Participating teams can bring their own data, so long as they meet the following criteria:

- Prize teams led by UK researchers must conduct research on datasets with UK cohorts. Prize teams led by South African researchers must conduct research on datasets with South African cohorts.
- Datasets must include data about respondents under 30 years of age (child / young person respondents) to enable research focused on those respondents.
- Datasets must be longitudinal, allowing for the investigation of temporal effects, with at least three waves of data capture for child / young person respondents.
- Datasets must include data from at least one age-appropriate measure of depression and/or anxiety (or their symptoms), used in child / young person respondents across multiple waves of longitudinal data collection. Proxy measures of these disorders or symptoms are permitted but should be well-justified.
- Datasets must include data suitable for exploring active ingredients of depression and/or anxiety in children and young people.

In addition to this, a selection of longitudinal datasets from the UK and South Africa will be proposed as appropriate ‘exemplar’ research data to participants, with streamlined access to these datasets facilitated where appropriate.

These exemplar datasets are longitudinal research studies and have been selected as they contain rich data that has the potential to provide new insights on active ingredients. Examples of these datasets are the Avon Longitudinal Study of Parents and Children (ALSPAC) and the Millennium Cohort Study.

Within their proposals, participants must be able to demonstrate both that their dataset is:

- appropriate for their research question and/or tool
- and that they have gained appropriate access to use this data within the prize.

If applicants have access to a dataset that does not meet all of the criteria above but provides other added value to address the research question set out, please contact us at datapriz@socialfinance.org.uk so we can assess on a case-by-case basis.

Teams that bring their own data must be prepared to share the insights they have found along with relevant data, in line with [Wellcome’s open access policy](#).

When submitting an application, all teams must ensure that they include the following information relating to the data they will use:

- The provenance of the data
- Data fields that will be used for research
- A cohort of study members that will be included in the research
- A timeframe of study data that will be included in the research
- An outline of why the chosen data is appropriate for addressing the research question
- Approval to access the data from the relevant data controller, if required
- Confirmation that the use of the data aligns with the legitimate basis for its collection and use
- Organisational data protection policies for safeguarding all data
- An outline of how the project will comply with local privacy laws and, where relevant, access protocols for restricted datasets
- Mitigations against any risks that research outputs may be misused for harmful purposes
- Steps that will be taken to make research outputs publicly available, including:
 - analytical dataset
 - source code for analysis and digital tools, along with sufficient data to enable others to understand, test, run and re-use these
 - research papers.

Evaluating dataset choice

As part of the evaluation process, the evaluation panel will be assessing the suitability of the datasets that applicants propose against these criteria. This applies to teams who intend to use one of the exemplar datasets as well as to teams who intend to propose an alternative dataset.

Prize team applicants must be able to evidence, with the submission of their prize application, confirmation from the relevant data controller that they are permitted to access the data required to pursue their research goals.

In some cases, it may not be possible for teams to gain approval to access highly sensitive data before the application deadline. In these cases, we expect:

- applications to include as much evidence as possible outlining the progress they have made with data holders to access these data and a likely timeframe for full access.
- teams to outline the adjustments they will make to their research proposal in the event they are denied access to sensitive data and the impact this will have on the outcomes of their research.

Applicants should also demonstrate why their choice of dataset is particularly suited to their research question and project goals.

Please be specific about the timeframe, cohort and data fields to be used and how your choice of these is appropriate for your research question.

Expectations for data ethics

As part of the evaluation of data prize applications, we will be evaluating the safeguards that teams have in place to ensure the ethical use of any data they will use. Prize teams must detail in their application the provisions they will have in place for ensuring:

- that their research question and use and any sharing of the data aligns with the provenance of the data and the legitimate basis for its collection
- clear protocols for the safeguarding of all data and in particular sensitive data
- compliance with local data privacy laws and, where relevant, compliance with any access protocols in relation to restricted access datasets or shared data platforms
- mitigations against the risk that their research may generate outcomes that could be misused for harmful purposes
- In all instances, organisational data protection policies must be included as an attachment to proposals to allow for a robust assessment of the safeguarding procedures applied to the proposed dataset/s.

Expectations for open science

Wellcome are committed to conducting mental health research in an open way and we invite prize participants to follow and, where possible, advance methods and ways of working that facilitate community-led research.

Where the data are concerned, we would expect all teams to follow these principles:

- Where relevant, appropriate and privacy-preserving, analytical datasets, along with variables created and transformed during research, should be made publicly available.
- All source code (for research and tool development) must be licensed under an OSI-compliant licence and must be hosted on a freely-available and publicly accessible collaboration repository, such as GitHub, GitLab or BitBucket.
- If any software (including any software tool) depends on or processes data then sufficient data must be made freely available to enable third parties to understand, test, run, and re-use the relevant software. This could be a small sub-set of data embedded into the code repository, or a link to data on a publicly-accessible repository.
- Publications resulting from prize research should be published in open access journals, wherever possible.

Please make reference to the [Wellcome Open access policy for further details](#).

We actively encourage prize participants to engage in a research community comprised of fellow prize teams. This includes sharing insights and outputs of research and collaborating on data science challenges specific to analysing longitudinal datasets. This will benefit from the development of open science methods that enable such sharing without disclosure of sensitive data about study respondents, such as the generation of synthetic datasets.

Exemplar datasets

We have consulted with several data holders in the UK and South Africa to build an understanding of the data that we consider to be appropriate for the prize. We have identified several exemplar datasets that meet all of the criteria above. The data holders of each of these datasets have been consulted on the most effective way to access their data, with details documented in the 'Exemplar datasets' PDF documents below.

We welcome applications from teams that propose to conduct their research on alternative datasets, provided they meet the criteria above. Applications proposing the use of such datasets will not be disadvantaged for selection.

When making an application to a data holder for access to a dataset, please use the prefix “Wellcome MH data prize” to your project title.

Evaluation criteria

Feasibility criteria

For each of the feasibility criteria, applicants will receive a pass or fail score. All the feasibility criteria need to receive a pass score as a prerequisite for selection.

Pass/fail (PF) feasibility criteria

1. Where relevant, the team has approval and has met all the appropriate requirements and standards to access the data required for their research from the relevant data controller.
2. The choice of dataset is appropriate to address the research question and aligns with the legitimate basis for collection and use.
3. The team demonstrates that they have adequate organisational data protocols to safeguard sensitive data that are consistent with applicable local and regional regulations.
4. The team has considered research ethics and data privacy and has a plan to mitigate against potential risks.
5. The team has provided a suitable research methodology to address their research question.
6. The team has considered time and resource implications in their research plan and has provided evidence that they will be able to make meaningful progress within the initial 6-month period.
7. The team shows evidence of sufficient time and resources and has a reasonable plan in place on how the initial prototype will be achieved during the 6-month prototyping phase.
8. The team have a plan that will involve the wider community in the project, by embedding mental health lived experience and/or sharing insights/methods with the research/data science community.
9. Team members have the appropriate skills and experience to be able to answer the research question.
10. Team members have the appropriate skills and experience to be able to develop the proposed tool.
11. Team members have the appropriate skills and experience to be able to deliver an involvement plan.

Application criteria

- Applications that pass the feasibility criteria will receive a score between 1 and 5 for both impact and innovation across each of the three criteria:

Research question

Impact

- The research question advances understanding of 'active ingredients' of effective interventions for anxiety and/or depression in young people, including what helps, for whom, in what contexts, and why (for example, mechanisms underpinning effectiveness). Outputs will point to how insights gained may impact young people experiencing anxiety and/or depression, having the potential to significantly impact either a wide range of people experiencing anxiety and/or depression, or a group who are not commonly represented within mental health research.
- Dataset variables and analytical methods are clearly articulated and well-suited to the research question.
Note: this criteria is designed to allow for a more nuanced evaluation of the proposals above the baseline feasibility criteria 1 and 5 below.
- As per the [Wellcome open access policy](#), the team provides a convincing summary approach of how they plan to ensure that all outputs, including publications, analytical datasets along with variables created and transformed during research, will be made publicly available.

Innovation

- The team demonstrates excellent understanding of the existing research connected with the chosen active ingredient and demonstrates that their research question is novel and has the potential for innovation in mental health science (for example, it could point the way towards improving existing early interventions for anxiety and/or depression, or developing new ones).
- The research methodology is innovative and has the potential for wider use in other research applications.
Note: it is not expected that the team must innovate in their methodology if this is not appropriate for their research.

Approach to tool development

Impact

- The proposed tool will aid/enable future research into youth anxiety and/or depression, and/or the active ingredients approach in mental health research.

- The proposed tool has applications within mental health research beyond the scope of this data prize. Note: it is not expected that the team must demonstrate this.
- Proposal details approaches that the team will take to make tools available for wider use, including using publicly accessible code repositories, providing sufficient data and testing to enable third parties to understand, test, run and re-use software.
- The approach to the prototype phase follows sensibly from discovery phase with consistency in planning

Innovation

- The proposed tool has the potential to provide a novel way of addressing data and/or research needs within mental health research into active ingredients.

Involvement

Impact

- There is evidence that the multidisciplinary composition of the team is crucial to the success and impact of the proposed project.
- The team shows a plan for how they will be working collaboratively to share and synergise their complementary expertise throughout the process (avoiding siloed work).
- Where relevant, the involvement plan will positively impact people with lived experience working on the project.
- The team has a plan to share work/embed research beyond the mental health research community.
- All key partners demonstrate a clear sense of their roles and have a consistent way of talking about the project aims and ways of working.

Innovation

- Team formation brings together organisations that have not traditionally worked together.
- The proposed team demonstrates one or more of the following:
 - a new, cross-disciplinary way of approaching research into active ingredients of depression and/or anxiety in young people
 - involvement with people with lived experience
 - the plan for working incorporates reflexive practice (awareness of influence a researcher has on the people/topic being studied), and significantly addresses the traditional power structure of a mental health research team
- Team formation and involvement plans:
 - promotes diversity and inclusion in terms of skills and background

- takes steps to be representative of the population involved in the research
- The involvement plan is innovative in the way the team intends to adapt to or have feedback strongly impact their research and tool production.
- The team approach has the potential to advance and share awareness of best practice use of data in the mental health research community.

Each of these criteria will be equally weighted. More details are in the '[Useful documents and links](#)' section. The best scoring teams will be invited to pitch.

- Pitches will provide an opportunity for applicants to provide more depth to their proposal and for the evaluation panel to ask questions.
- After the pitch, the 10 prize teams will be selected.

Selection panel

Applications will be reviewed by the following panel:

- Professor Ann John (Chair), Co-Director DATAMIND, Swansea University
- Stefaan G. Verhulst, Co-founder and Chief Research and Development Officer, The Governance Laboratory at New York University
- Professor Andrea Mechelli, Institute of Psychiatry, Psychology & Neuroscience, King's College London
- Professor Crick Lund, Professor of Global Mental Health, Centre for Global Mental Health, King's College London and Honorary Professor, Alan J Fisher Centre for Public Mental Health, Department of Psychiatry and Mental Health, University of Cape Town
- Professor Katherine Sorsdahl, Co-Director, Alan J Fisher Centre for Public Mental Health Department of Psychiatry and Mental Health, University of Cape Town
- Jodie Crooks, Research Assistant, University of Leeds (Lived Experience Expert)
- Jaimie Lee Davids, Training Officer, Waves for Change (Lived Experience Expert)
- Alessandra Fassio, Advocacy and Relations Manager – Data for Children Collaborative with UNICEF

What we offer

Funding, support, expenses and what we don't offer

There are three phases to the prize, each six months long and with different levels of funding and support on offer:

- **Discovery Phase:** an initial 10 teams will be selected to receive £40,000 of funding.
- **Prototyping Phase:** five teams from the Discovery Phase will receive £100,000.

- **Sustainability Phase:** three winning teams will receive £165,000.

The amounts listed are per team. Throughout the prize, teams will be supported with data access, analysis and use case development as well as support on planning lived experience involvement approaches.

There will also be regular group activities such as problem-solving sessions and theory of change workshops.

You should ask for a level of funding that is justifiable for your proposed research. You must justify all costs within the costs section of your application.

The award includes:
staff

You can ask for a contribution to your salary if you hold a permanent, open-ended or long-term rolling contract that states that you have to get your salary from external grant funding.

The amount we pay will be proportionate to the time you contribute to the award, for example if you contribute 30% of your time to the award, we will fund 30% of your salary.

Your host organisation must confirm:

- that your employment contract states you must get salary recovery from external grant funding
- that they will underwrite the post, including any salary costs not covered by Wellcome, for the period of time that you will be working on the grant.

Coapplicants

If any coapplicant employed on the grant holds a permanent, open-ended or long-term rolling contract that requires them to get their salary from external grant funding or they are self-employed, you can ask us for a contribution to their salary in your application.

The amount we pay will be proportionate to the time they contribute to the award, for example if they contribute 30% of their time to the award, we will fund 30% of their salary.

Your host organisation must confirm:

- that the coapplicant's employment contract states they must get salary recovery from external grant funding

- that they will underwrite the post, including any salary costs not covered by Wellcome, for the period of time that the person will be working on the grant.

For any staff or applicants working on the award, you will need to be able to provide evidence of the time spent working on the award.

We will provide the salary costs for staff, full or part-time, who work on your project.

We do not provide studentships on this award.

How to cost salaries for research staff

Staff salaries should be appropriate to skills, responsibilities and expertise. You should ask your host organisation to use their salary scales to calculate these costs, which should include:

- basic salary
- employer's contributions, including any statutory obligations (for example, National Insurance contributions if you're based in the UK) and pension scheme costs
- Apprentice Levy charges for UK-based salaries
- any incremental progression up the salary scale
- locally recognised allowances such as London allowance.

Read about the [responsibilities of grantholders and host organisations for people working on a Wellcome grant](#).

Visa and work permit costs

If you have named people on your grant whose salaries will be funded by Wellcome, you can ask for visa or work permit costs to help them take up their posts at the host organisation. You can also ask for:

- visa costs for the person's partner and dependent children
- essential associated costs, such as travel to attend appointments at a visa application centre or embassy, and essential English language tests
- Immigration Health Surcharge costs for the person, their partner and dependent children if they will be in the UK for six months or more.

Disability-related adjustment support

If you or a member of staff working on your grant is disabled or has a long-term health condition, you can ask for adjustment support to help you carry out your project.

Costs can include, but are not limited to:

- additional costs for staff to help with day-to-day activities related to your project

- assistive technology to help use computers, research equipment or materials – for example, text to audio software
- care costs for assistance animals if you need to travel.

We will not pay for capital or building costs, such as access ramps.

You can ask for these costs if your government and/or employer:

- does not cover any of the costs
- only covers some of the costs (if they do, we will only meet the shortfall).

The costs we provide must not replace the support you may get from the government or your organisation, who are responsible for providing these costs.

If you don't know what these costs are now, you can [ask for them after we've awarded your grant](#).

materials and consumables

We will pay for the materials and consumables you need to carry out your project.

equipment

Equipment purchase

Your chosen research environment should have the necessary equipment for you to complete your work. You can ask for additional basic items of equipment that are essential to your research project.

Costs may include purchase, delivery, installation, maintenance and training, where necessary.

We will cover VAT and import duties if:

- the usual UK exemptions on equipment used for medical research don't apply
- you're applying from a non-UK organisation, and you can show these costs can't be recovered.

You can also ask for specialised equipment if:

- it is essential to the success of the proposed research project
- it is not available at your host organisation or through collaboration, and
- you'll be the main user and have priority access to the equipment.

Computer equipment

We will cover the cost of one personal computer or laptop per person up to £1,500.

We won't pay for:

- more expensive items, **unless** you can justify them
- installation or training costs.

access charges

You can ask for the cost of access to shared equipment, facilities or services if they're essential to your project.

These may include materials and consumables, plus a proportion of:

- maintenance and service contracts
- staff time costs for dedicated technical staff employed to operate the equipment or facility.

We don't cover the costs of:

- estates and utilities
- depreciation or insurance
- other staff, for example, contributions towards departmental technical, administrative and management staff time.

We do cover these costs if related to animal housing facilities.

If the facilities or equipment were paid for by a Wellcome grant, you can only ask for access charges if:

- the grant has ended
- any support for running costs and maintenance contracts has ended.

overheads

You can ask for overheads if your grant will be based at a:

- university outside the UK or Republic of Ireland
- research organisation that does not receive core funding for overheads
- charitable or not-for-profit organisation
- small or medium-sized commercial organisation.

You can also ask for overheads on any part of your grant that is sub-contracted to any of the organisations listed above.

If you're based at a UK university you can't ask for overheads for sub-contracted activity if your university will include the sub-contracted funding in its annual report to the UK Charity Research Support Fund.

Overheads can include:

- estates, for example building and premises
- non-project dedicated administrative and support staff
- administration, for example finance, library, and room hire.

The total cost for overheads should not be more than:

- 20% of the direct research costs if you're based in a low- or middle-income country
- 15% of the direct research costs if you're based anywhere else.

These costs must directly support the activity funded by the grant.

How to apply for these costs

In your grant application you must:

- give a full breakdown of costs (you can't ask for a percentage of the research costs)
- explain why these costs are necessary for your research
- include a letter from the finance director of your host organisation, or the sub-contracted organisation, confirming that the breakdown is a true representation of the costs incurred.

travel and subsistence

Conference attendance

You can ask for a contribution towards the costs of attending scientific and academic meetings and conferences, including registration fees and the costs to offset the carbon emissions of your travel.

We provide costs to cover caring responsibilities if you or any staff employed on your grant attend a conference. This includes childcare and any other caring responsibility you have. We will pay these if:

- Wellcome is providing the salary
- the conference is directly related to the research
- the caring costs are over and above what they'd normally pay for care

- the conference organiser and their employing organisation are unable to cover the costs.

You can ask for up to £1,000 per person for each conference.

Collaborative travel

You can ask for travel and subsistence costs for collaborative visits for you and any staff employed on your grant. You'll need to justify each visit and its duration.

Other travel

We will pay for other essential visits, for example to facilities, for sample collection and for fieldwork. You can include subsistence costs.

Carbon offset costs

This applies to all types of travel costs Wellcome provides.

You can ask for:

- essential travel costs, even if the low carbon option is more expensive (for example travelling by train instead of flying)
- project-related resources or activities that provide an alternative to travel, such as video conferencing, communication and file-sharing software
- costs to offset the carbon emissions generated by the essential travel. If carbon offsetting for travel is not part of your organisational sustainability strategy, you can ask us for a similar level of support for other sustainability initiatives. Your organisation must get our approval before submitting an application.

We won't pay for the core infrastructure that your host organisation should provide, unless you're eligible to ask for these costs under our [overheads policy](#). Examples of these costs include:

- organisation-wide video conferencing packages
- high-speed broadband
- HD screens.

See our [carbon offset policy](#) for travel for information on what you and your organisation need to do.

Subsistence costs

If you're away for **up to one month** you can ask for subsistence costs. These include accommodation, meals and incidentals (for example, refreshments or newspapers).

If your administering organisation has a subsistence policy, use their rates.

If your administering organisation doesn't have a subsistence policy, please use the [HMRC rates](#).

If you're away for **more than one month and up to 12 months**, we will pay reasonable rental costs only, including aparthotels. You should discuss appropriate rates with your administering and host organisations, or Wellcome, as appropriate. We expect you to choose the most economical options, booked in advance where possible.

If you're from a low- or middle- income country and will be working in a high-income country for **more than one month and up to 12 months**, you can also ask for up to £10 a day to cover extra costs, such as transport and incidentals.

The allowance we provide will be based on family and business need. We will set the maximum allowance we pay for each location. This will be based on current market data or, where data is unavailable, in consultation with your administering organisation, using equivalent market rates. Please [contact us](#) if you need help calculating the costs.

We will cover the direct expenses you have to pay to find and rent a home. We will not cover the cost of utilities or any refurbishment.

Overseas research

If you or any research staff employed on your grant will be doing research away from your home laboratory, we'll help with the additional costs of working on the project overseas. Please see the 'Overseas allowances' section for details.

overseas allowances

If you or any staff employed on your grant will be spending time in another country, we'll help you with the additional costs of working on the project overseas.

Our overseas allowances are:

- a contribution towards the personal cost of carrying out research overseas, to ensure that you are not disadvantaged
- provided on the assumption that you'll be paying income tax, either in your home country, or the country you will be working in (your personal tax is your responsibility)
- provided on the understanding that you or your partner will not receive equivalent allowances from elsewhere
- determined by the amount of time you will spend away from your home country.

Carbon offset costs

We expect the people we fund to choose travel that has a lower carbon impact, where practical, even if it's more expensive (for example travelling by train instead of flying).

You can ask for costs to offset the carbon generated by the travel, as part of your overseas allowances. If carbon offsetting for travel is not part of your organisational sustainability strategy, you can ask us for a similar level of support for other sustainability initiatives. Your organisation must get our approval for other sustainability initiatives to be included in applications.

See our [carbon offset policy](#) for travel for information on what you and your organisation need to do.

Partners and dependants travelling with you[Show](#)

See a list of [low- and middle-income countries](#), as defined by the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD).

You can ask for the following allowances. You need to provide estimated costs as accurately as possible.

outward and return travel[Show](#)

baggage and freight shipping allowance[Show](#)

medical and travel insurance[Show](#)

visas and vaccinations[Show](#)

housing security[Show](#)

accommodation and subsistence[Show](#)

open access charges[Show](#)

public engagement and patient involvement costs[Show](#)

contract research organisations[Show](#)

other costs

Allowed costs

You may ask for the following costs (you will have to justify them in your application):

- specialist publications that are relevant to the research and not available in institutional libraries
- consultancy fees
- expenses for subjects and volunteers – includes recruitment of participants, their participatory fees and travel, as well as interviewee expenses
- reasonable research-associated costs related to the feedback of [health-related findings](#) but not any healthcare-associated costs
- costs associated with developing an [outputs management plan](#)

- questionnaires, recruitment material, newsletters etc for clinical, epidemiological and qualitative research studies
- recruitment, advertising and interviewee travel costs for staff to be employed on the grant
- purchase, hire and running costs of project-dedicated vehicles
- project-specific personal protective equipment (PPE) that is above the standard expected for the setting
- computing, including recurrent costs dedicated to the project (for example, software licences).

Disallowed costs

We will not pay for:

- estates costs – such as building and premises costs, basic services and utilities. This also includes phone, postage, photocopying and stationery, unless you can justify these within a clinical or epidemiological study.
- page charges and the cost of colour prints
- research, technical and administrative staff whose time is shared across several projects and isn't supported by an audit record
- PhD stipends
- charge-out costs for major facilities – departmental technical and administrative services, and use of existing equipment
- cleaning, waste and other disposal costs
- indirect costs – this includes general administration costs such as personnel, finance, library, room hire and some departmental services
- office furniture, such as chairs, desks and filing cabinets
- clothing, such as lab coats and shoes
- non-research related activities such as catering, room and venue hire for staff parties, team-building events and social activities
- indemnity insurance (insurance cover against claims made by subjects or patients associated with a research programme)
- ethics reviews, unless you are in a low- or middle-income country
- radiation protection costs
- contingency funds
- organisation insurance
- clinical examination or course fees
- working capital costs of commercial organisations.

What we don't offer

See 'Other costs' for the costs we will and will not provide.

How to apply

Stages of application

Teams will apply with a written proposal and shortlisted teams will be asked to present their proposals to a panel.

1. Before you apply

Make sure you read everything on this page.

2. Submit your application

- [View the sample application form \[PDF 194KB\]](#) to understand what you will need to include in your application.
- Complete your application on [Wellcomedataprizesubmit.com](https://wellcomedataprizesubmit.com)

3. Evaluation

Applications will be reviewed based on their feasibility, impact and innovation. For details please see the evaluation criteria.

4. Selection process

Initial Application Review

Social Finance will review applications for eligibility and appropriate data access for teams that wish to use their own datasets.

Panel Application Review

The selection panel and data ethics advisor will review the relevant sections of each application based on their area of expertise. Applications will be assessed using the evaluation criteria and up to twenty teams will be shortlisted.

Panel presentations

Shortlisted teams will be asked to present to the selection panel who will use the evaluation criteria to select the final ten teams.

Funding decision

Final funding decisions will be made by Wellcome following the recommendation from the judging panel. Please note we are not able to provide feedback to unsuccessful applicants

5. Progression to Prototyping phase

Teams will be evaluated on their progress and performance in the Discovery Phase and five teams will be selected to take part in the Prototyping phase. Evaluation will be carried out by a selection panel chosen for their expertise in relevant fields.

Disabled applicants

If you are disabled or have a long-term health condition, [we can support you with the application process](#).

Source (3/3):

<https://wellcome.org/news/listening-scientists-across-africa-develop-our-next-mental-health-data-prize>

Listening to scientists from across Africa to develop our next Mental Health Data Prize

Our first Mental Health Data Prize is generating exciting new research opportunities for data scientists, primarily in the UK. Read about how we're tailoring our next prize for research communities across Africa.

Last year, we launched our first [Mental Health Data Prize](#), with the goal of funding at the intersection of data science and mental health. We wanted to include datasets from at least one low- and middle-income country and one high-income country. Our initial scoping suggested promising data sources in the UK and South Africa, so we decided to focus on these two countries.

When we designed the prize, along with our partners [Social Finance](#), we engaged with mental health researchers, data holders and young people with lived experience to shape the prize for the UK and South Africa.

This engagement generated excitement and interest before the launch, suggesting we had designed something that works for the community.

But we didn't receive as many applications from South Africa as we'd hoped. In the first phase of the prize, we funded ten teams from the UK and only one from South Africa.

We had a hunch that this was due to the way we had structured and designed the prize. So, we went back to the community who expressed interest, and others we hadn't spoken to before, to understand why.

Why hadn't people applied? What can we do differently in South Africa?

To find out, we ran a follow-up evaluation involving a qualitative survey, a workshop with African data scientists and expert consultations with relevant stakeholders.

We also ran a workshop at the Data Science for Health Discovery and Innovation in Africa (DS-I Africa) Initiative's annual meeting, to hear from that community what funders need to consider when supporting health data science in Africa.

What we heard about how to improve the Mental Health Data Prize

The consultation was revealing – we heard lots of constructive feedback about how to tailor the prize more appropriately to research communities in South Africa.

Some of the areas that came up repeatedly were:

- Our **eligibility criteria should be more flexible**, especially when it comes to (co)leadership (for example, mandating the lead to be from the setting in which the data has been collected – which we had done – may have been overly limiting; we may need to ensure the benefits from the work goes to local communities via other means).
- **Longer timelines** for application preparation and team formation would be useful.
- **The work required to apply was viewed as too burdensome in resource-limited settings**, given the relatively small amount of funding on offer.
- **Forming a team** with the necessary skills to both analyse data and build a digital tool was challenging within the timeframe.
- A lack of clarity on **future funding opportunities** after the prize was off-putting.

We also heard that rather than focusing the prize on South Africa, we should consider opening the prize to teams across Africa. We heard from researchers from Kenya, the Gambia and Uganda who would have applied if the scope allowed.

What we're doing now

Based on what we've heard, we will be running a new Mental Health Data Prize open to teams across the African continent, which we hope will be better tailored to the needs and priorities of data scientists and mental health researchers in Africa.

Right now, [were searching for a partner, preferably based in Africa, that will set up the prize \[PDF 412KB\]](#).

The delivery partner will manage the engagement, training, and team formation stages, involving data scientists and mental health researchers from across Africa. Areas for training and support will be identified by crowd-sourcing ideas from the interested community to best tailor it to their needs.

After the initial engagement and set up phase, teams will be invited to submit proposals that use existing data from across the continent. Their goal? To improve understanding of the trajectory and resolution of anxiety, depression, and psychosis in different African contexts.

Ekin Bolukbasi

Data Prizes Manager

Wellcome

Ekin manages data prizes in the Data for Science and Health team at Wellcome. She has a background in genetics and cell biology and is responsible for designing the data prizes programme to advance Wellcome's strategies across its three health challenges and discovery research.